5 Things to Check Before the First Freeze

Most years the Columbus area gets its first frost in October and its first hard freeze, 28°F or colder, in late October or November. Knock these out before then. Plan on about an hour, plus the sprinkler company if you have a system.

1 Outside faucets: hoses off, lines drained

- [ ] Take every hose off, including on frost free faucets. A frost free faucet only drains when nothing is attached. A hose left on over a cold night is how they split inside the wall, and you won't see the leak until spring.
- [ ] Older standard faucets: close the shutoff valve inside the house, then open the outside faucet and leave it open for winter so it can drain. If the inside valve has a small drain cap, open it over a bucket.
- [ ] Put a foam cover on each faucet. They cost a few dollars at any hardware store.
- [ ] No inside shutoff? That's common in newer homes. Frost free faucets are fine as long as the hose is off.

2 Sprinklers: water off, lines blown out, backflow protected

- [ ] Shut off the water supply to the system and set the controller to off.
- [ ] Have the lines blown out with compressed air. This is usually a job for your sprinkler company, since too much pressure can damage heads and valves.
- [ ] Look at the backflow preventer, the brass assembly usually near the foundation outside. It sits above ground and freezes easily. Make sure it was drained and its valves were left the way your installer recommends, then insulate it.

3 Pipes in cold spots

- [ ] Walk the garage, crawlspace, unheated rooms, and any sink on an outside wall. Kitchen sinks on exterior walls and bathrooms over a garage are the usual trouble spots.
- [ ] Put foam pipe insulation on exposed lines and seal drafts where pipes pass through walls and along the basement rim joist.
- [ ] Keep the garage door closed during cold snaps. If you'll be away, leave the heat at 55°F or higher.
- [ ] On the coldest nights, open the cabinet doors under sinks on outside walls and let the faucet drip.

4 Sump pump and its discharge line

- [ ] Slowly pour a bucket of water into the pit. The pump should turn on, empty the pit, and shut itself off.
- [ ] Go outside while it runs. Water should come out where it's supposed to and flow away from the house.
- [ ] Make sure the discharge line isn't crushed, clogged with leaves, or dumping into a low spot where it can freeze solid. An iced over outlet can back water up into the basement.
- [ ] If you have a battery backup or a high water alarm, test that too.

5 Find your main water shutoff and make sure it turns

- [ ] It's usually in the basement or utility room, where the water line comes through the floor or wall near the meter.
- [ ] Turn it slowly to off, then back on. If it's stuck or the handle feels brittle, don't force it. Call a plumber to look at it.
- [ ] Tag it and show everyone in the house where it is. If a pipe ever bursts, this is the valve that saves your floors.

WHILE YOU'RE AT IT

Change the furnace filter, clean the gutters and point the downspouts away from the house, and test your smoke and CO alarms.

Rather have it done for you? A Fall Freeze Prep visit is $129 flat, about 45 minutes. 1614home.co/freeze

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General guidance for typical homes. If a valve is stuck, a pipe is leaking, or anything looks wrong, call a licensed plumber.